American Red Cross

Job Tool: When and How to Offer Disaster Mental Health Services to Clients and Responders

Disaster Cycle Services Job Tools
DCS JT Respond/Disaster Mental Health

Audience

This job tool is for disaster workers who work with disaster clients, including caseworkers, disaster action team members, shelter workers, and reunification workers.

Overview

The disaster worker is on the "front lines" of a relief operation and is often the first person to speak with those impacted by the disaster. The 3R's (reactions to the stress of the event, risk factors and an individual's resilience -- or lack of resilience) provide information that can help determine if a client would benefit from a referral to Disaster Mental Health workers. The 3R's help determine how well an individual will react and cope with the stressors of the disaster.

An individual who has unexpected reactions, more personal risk exposure, and/or difficulty coping should be referred to a Disaster Mental Health worker. Any time a disaster worker thinks that a person is having difficulty coping and needs referral, the worker should trust their intuition and refer this person. See the "When to Refer to DMH" Reference Card.**

When to Offer a Referral for Disaster Mental Health Services to a Client

Referral Needed **Immediately**

Workers should refer a client/worker <u>immediately</u> to Disaster Mental Health if he/she is:

- In danger of harming self/another – **call 911 NOW (before contacting Disaster Mental Health.)**
- Unable to care for her/himself
- In severe emotional distress
- Confused or disoriented

Contact a Disaster Mental Health worker immediately either by phone or in person when Possible. If a disaster mental health worker is not available, call 911.

Referral Needed <u>As Soon As Possible</u>

As individuals share their disaster stories listen for the following which indicate you should notify a Disaster Mental Health worker as soon as possible.

Concerning Reactions		Risk Factors**		Resilience
Family/friends concerned about behavior	And/ Or	Family, friend, pet killed	And/ Or	Has no family/community support
Unexpected reactions to stress		Felt threat to life		Has no financial resources
		Witnessed death/injury		
		Separated from family/caregiver		Lacks good coping skills
		Community destroyed		

Referral Needed By the End of the Shift

Many individuals would benefit from a referral to a Disaster Mental Health worker but the following risks are less urgent.

Concerning Reactions		Risk Factors		Resilience
Difficulty thinking/concentrating	And/ Or	Home destroyed	And/ Or	Appears to have some positive coping skills
Anxiety/nervousness		Assisted with rescue/recovery		
		Sheltered in place		Has some community/family support
Significant physical complaints		Has severe financial loss (business destroyed)		

"Taking Care of Yourself" Editable Wallet Card

Give each client the "Taking Care of Yourself" Wallet Card containing the national 24/7 Disaster Distress Helpline number as well as a local crisis number. Everyone goes through a different process of coping and adjusting to the stress of disaster. People may have a strong emotional reaction until in the middle of the night or at a time when they feel ashamed or embarrassed to tell friends or family that they need help. By providing the "Taking Care of Yourself" Wallet Card, you are making sure that each Red Cross disaster client has 24/7 access to confidential emotional support. See the Job Tool: "Taking Care of Yourself" Editable Wallet Card for more instructions about how to customize the card with local information.

How to Offer Disaster Mental Health Services to a Client

Some workers may feel uncomfortable offering a Disaster Mental Health referral to a client. Below are some tips and examples of language workers can use to discuss Disaster Mental Health with clients.

Tips for offering Disaster Mental Health support:

- **Avoid stigma:** If concerned about stigma, refer to Disaster Mental Health workers as "disaster counselors" or "stress counselors."
- **Keep things simple:** Simply ask the client if he/she would like to talk to someone who can help with coping strategies.
- **Don't judge:** A client may benefit from having someone to talk to after experiencing a traumatic or highly stressful event.
- **Ask about others:** Sometimes people are more comfortable requesting help for a loved one they are concerned about than for themselves.
- **Focus on Children:** Offer Disaster Mental Health services to parents who are concerned about whether their child is coping and adjusting well after a disaster.

Examples of what to say:

- "The Red Cross has disaster counselors who talk with people who have experienced a fire [or hurricane, flood, or other disaster]. Would you like a call from a disaster counselor?"
- "Red Cross counselors are trained to help people manage the disaster stress including helping you manage the challenges you are facing right now and what your family can expect down the road."

- "Children have different reactions to disasters than adults. The Red Cross has counselors you can talk to if you are worried about your children or just want to know what behaviors to keep an eye out for. Would you like to be contacted by a Red Cross counselor?"
- "You mentioned you (or your wife/child/father) have been treated for a mental health condition in the past. The Red Cross has disaster counselors who can help you (or he/she) identify strategies for coping with the extreme stress you (or he/she) are experiencing. Would you (or he/she) like to talk to a Red Cross counselor?"

When to Offer a Referral for Disaster Mental Health Services to a Worker

Disaster Mental Health Services also supports Red Cross Disaster employees and volunteers. Workers should consider requesting Disaster Mental Health Services for themselves or coworkers during or after an especially disturbing assignment. Some examples may include when a worker:

Concerning Reactions		Risk Factors		Resilience
Continues to think about a specific incident/client/topic	And/ Or	Witnessed serious/fatal injuries	And/ Or	Displays negative/poor coping strategies
Difficulty sleeping		Witnessed massive destruction		
Conflicts with other volunteers/staff members		Destruction of own community		
		Felt life was in danger		
		Worked with exploitive or unappreciative clients		

How to Make a Referral to Disaster Mental Health

Referral Needed Immediately

When a Disaster Mental Health worker is physically present

- When a Disaster Mental Health worker is physically present to support a client at a disaster scene, a shelter or another service delivery location, make a referral directly to the Disaster Mental Health worker by talking to him/her in person. When possible, introduce the client to the Disaster Mental Health worker.

When a Disaster Mental Health worker is not present

- Call the on-call Disaster Mental Health worker (or the established Disaster Mental Health phone number when on a Disaster Response Operation) and hand the phone to the client to ensure the connection is made.

Referral Needed by the End of the Shift

Client

- Ask when would be a good time for a Red Cross counselor to follow up with them. Complete the referral is to document the request in CAS 2.0 to ensure the Disaster Mental Health team is aware of the client's need. See the Job Tool: Documenting Disaster Health Services and Disaster Mental Health Information in CAS 2.0 for more details.

- If documentation in CAS 2.0 is not an option, use your best judgment to connect the client to a Disaster Mental Health worker while maintaining the client's confidentiality.

Worker

- Talk with the worker and recommend that he/she contacts a Disaster Mental Health worker for assistance.
- If necessary, notify the Disaster Mental Health supervisor assigned to that site and report your concerns. Maintain the worker's confidentiality. Do not discuss your concerns with others.